

Gender Responsive and Inclusive Politics and Economics in the MENA Region (Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon, Morocco, Palestinian Territories, Tunisia)

The challenge

The countries in the MENA region are characterised by a patriarchal gender paradigm that establishes a particular set of norms, values, expected behaviours and gender roles. Harassment at the workplace and in public spaces is a significant barrier to the political and economic participation of women. Women are under-represented at the political level and consequently have little scope to influence political and economic decisions. On average, in 2025, only 15.1% of parliamentarians in MENA countries are women. The region also has some of the world's lowest levels of women employment: 20% in Egypt, 15.6% in Jordan, 25.6% in Lebanon, 23.4% in Morocco, 18% in the Palestinian territories and 28.1% in Tunisia. At both national and company level, the very low proportion of women in the workforce represents a huge economic loss. This remains so despite some MENA region countries' efforts to adopt rules specifying a minimum level of women representation. As a result, their requirements and perspectives are largely excluded from national and regional negotiation processes on political and economic issues.



Project Name	WoMENA - Gender Responsive and Inclusive Politics and Economics in the MENA Region (WoMENA)
Commissioned by	German Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development (BMZ)
Project Region	Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon, Morocco, Palestine, Tunisia
Partner	Arab Women Organization (AWO)
Contact	Omar Bennouna Zhar Technical Advisor 114, rue Abdelmalek ben Marouane, quartier de l'aviation OLM, Souissi Rabat, Maroc E omar.bennouna@giz.de W www.giz.de
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Objective

The project aims to strengthen the political and economic participation of women in the MENA region in order to raise women representation in decision-making positions in political and economic life and to improve the opportunities available to women in the labour market and in working life.

Our approach

The project focuses on increasing women's political and economic participation in the MENA region through targeted actions and collaborations. The overarching aim is to help empower and promote their fundamental human rights and to ensure they can make an effective contribution towards shaping policies that promote gender equality and inclusion in the MENA region. In Morocco, the working group on Unpaid Care, composed of national experts from the public sector, private companies and civil society, has developed a roadmap for the professionalisation of maternal assistants, a crucial profession with major social and economic implications



Members of the Moroccan national working group on Unpaid Care and Domestic Work with the WoMENA team during their participation in a regional workshop. @GIZ

The project provides advice and capacity development support to make the work of economic and political change agents in the MENA region more effective. It targets economically and politically active women and girls (defined as aged between 15 and 18) who are limited in their economic and political participation. Special consideration is given to the needs of women with disabilities who suffer from multiple discrimination. In Morocco, the project deployed during its first phase (2022-2025) the post-earthquake initiative “Creative Spaces” to empower over 200 women from the villages affected. The integrated training programme for women in management and product marketing has also been reinforced by psychological support (listening sessions, cultural and recreational activities).



Members of the feminine cooperatives from Al Haouz standing next to the Creative Spaces. @GIZ



Women from the feminine local cooperatives of the Draa-Tafilalet region during the training session on e-commerce. @GIZ

Awareness raising activities are conducted among different age groups that promote an active role for women in political and economic life. In the same spirit, the active engagement of men for equality and women's rights is promoted. Through the flagship yearly activity of the Girl's Days, WoMENA is engaging companies from the private sector (industry, agroindustry, IT and services) to offer an immersive experience for middle school girls (15 to 19 years). In 2024, 120 Moroccan girls, partly from the Al Haouz region impacted by the earthquake, had the opportunity to explore different professions.



A group of young high school girls visiting the Nouaceur Aeropole in Casablanca during the Girl's Days in 2024. @GIZ

During its first phase, WoMENA supported 17 regional networks and 61 organisations in implementing measures to promote the political and economic participation of women in the MENA-region. By strengthening the capacities of more than 190 change-agents in all six countries, more than 5000 women and girls were reached.